

CORE FORMULA

Surface content: what actually happened? -> **Value clue:** what mattered in it - fairness, reliability, respect, craft, safety, belonging? -> **Tentative phrase:** "It sounds like..." / "Part of this may be..." / "I may be off, but..." -> **Calibration:** do they soften, add detail, clarify or correct? -> **Recovery:** "I may be reading that wrong - use your wording, not mine."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one likely value tentatively and leave room for correction: "It sounds like the fairness piece really mattered there - tell me if that is off."

BEST FOR

- When someone repeats a concern even after the facts are understood.
- When a complaint carries a fairness, respect, trust, safety or autonomy signal.
- When excitement reveals craft, contribution, challenge, belonging or growth.
- When a person seems more affected by what an event represents than by the event itself.
- When advice would be premature and the underlying stake needs recognising first.

PHRASE BANK

Starter reflections · Quick one-liners

- "It sounds like the fairness piece really mattered there."
- "Sounds like loyalty was the part that hurt."
- "Part of this seems to be about trust, not just timing."
- "The respect part seems to matter more than the logistics."
- "Sounds like this is less about the one incident and more about trust."
- "The trust piece seems important here."

Social and everyday · Warmth, belonging, honesty

- "It sounds like loyalty mattered there."
- "That seems like it touched the belonging piece."
- "I can hear how much honesty matters in this."
- "It sounds like you wanted the effort to be recognised."
- "It sounds like you cared about doing it properly, not just getting it done."
- "The thing you keep coming back to seems to be being taken seriously."

Work and standards · Meetings, delivery, decisions

- "It sounds like the standard mattered to you, not only the deadline."
- "This seems tied to ownership and follow-through."
- "It sounds like predictability would make this easier to work with."
- "It sounds like reliability is the issue more than the change itself."
- "It sounds like being part of the plan mattered, not just the outcome."
- "Part of this seems to be about what you could rely on."

Naming the value · One clear value, checked

- "It sounds like the fairness piece is what made this land so strongly."
- "The respect piece seems to matter more than the logistics alone."
- "It sounds like having room to choose was important there."
- "It sounds like doing it properly mattered, not just finishing it."

- "It sounds like you wanted the work to mean something."
- "The thread I am hearing is reliability. Correct me if that is off."
- "I may be off, but it sounds like reliability was the real issue."

Digital and text · Short written reflections

- "I may be reading this wrong, but the key value seems to be fairness."
- "Sounds like the main thread here is trust, not the single incident."
- "The bit you keep returning to seems to be being kept in the loop."
- "It reads like fairness is the part that stung. Tell me if that is off."
- "Happy to stay practical, but it sounds like respect is the real issue."

Correction space and release · Hand it back

- "Tell me if that is off."
- "I may be reading that wrong."
- "Use your wording, not mine."
- "That may be too strong a read."
- "We do not have to frame it that way."
- "We can keep this practical if that is more useful."
- "I do not want to put values in your mouth."
- "What would be the more accurate word?"

High-pressure and conflict · Safety, dignity, stakes

- "Let me check the value at stake before we solve it."
- "I do not want to overread this, but is the safety piece the main concern?"
- "It sounds like respect is the part we need to protect while we decide next steps."
- "Before we decide, I want to check the value we need to protect: is it safety, choice, or something else?"
- "It sounds like the safety piece is central here. Correct me if I have that wrong."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: You are obsessed with fairness.
Better: Fairness matters to you.
Best: It sounds like the fairness piece really mattered in how this landed.
- Weak: You clearly have trust issues.
Better: This involved trust.
Best: Part of this seems to be about what you could rely on.
- Weak: You just need control.
Better: Autonomy is important here.
Best: It sounds like having some room to choose was a big part of it.
- Weak: You care too much about being respected.
Better: Respect is part of this.
Best: The respect piece seems to be what made it feel bigger than the task.
- Weak: You are a perfectionist.
Better: Quality matters to you.
Best: It sounds like doing it properly mattered more than just finishing it.

DECISION TREE

If They are still telling the story.

Keep listening; do not name a value yet.

If A value word is explicit.

Reflect their exact word rather than inventing one.

"So the word you keep using is fairness."

If A value is implied but unspoken.

Offer it tentatively and leave correction space.

"I may be off, but it sounds like reliability mattered there."

If Several values are possible.

Choose the smallest that fits, or ask.

"Was the hard part the trust, or the timing?"

If They correct you.

Accept it at once and switch to their word.

"Fair enough - respect is the better word."

If They go flat, or the moment needs action.

Release the read; return to content or act directly.

"Let's stay practical - what needs to happen next?"

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation - a friend keeps returning to someone "not showing up."

Reflect the value gently and stay with their wording if they nod. — "Sounds like loyalty is the part that hurt."

Workplace - a colleague keeps stressing last-minute changes.

Name the value under the complaint, then summarise and move to action if they clarify the operational need. — "It sounds like reliability is the issue more than the change itself."

Conflict or repair - they say "it wasn't about the money."

Offer the likely value and accept a correction immediately. — "It sounds like respect was the bigger piece. Tell me if that is off."

Digital message - a long note that repeats one principle.

Reflect the single thread; do not pile on follow-up questions. — "I may be reading this wrong, but the thread I hear is fairness."

High-stakes - safety, dignity, choice or trust is visibly at stake.

Check the value to protect out loud; if pressure rises, switch to direct safety and action language. — "Before we decide, I want to check the value we need to protect: is it safety, choice, or something else?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person wants practical information, not reflection.
- You have too little evidence and would be guessing wildly.
- The value read would sound grand, invasive, moralising or strategic.
- The relationship is not safe enough for depth.
- The person is dysregulated and needs grounding, action or direct care before interpretation.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Collect real lines

Write five sentences someone might say after a frustrating or meaningful event - drawn from your own week where you can.

Day 2 — Separate fact from value

For each line, underline the surface fact, then circle the possible value cue underneath it.

Day 3 — Draft the reflection

Write one tentative value reflection under twelve words for each line, starting with "It sounds like..." or "Part of this may be..."

Day 4 — Add correction space

Attach a correction handle to each reflection - "tell me if that is off", "use your wording, not mine" - so the person can decline it.

Day 5 — Cut the overclaim

Strike any moralising, diagnostic or grand wording, and any personality labels. Reduce every stacked reflection to a single

value.

Day 6 — Say it aloud

Read each line in an ordinary voice. Rewrite anything that sounds like a clever interpretation rather than plain attention.

Day 7 — Use it live

In one low-stakes real conversation, offer a single value reflection, watch the signal, and note whether you should have gone smaller.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I reflect a value they signalled, not one I wanted them to have?
- Did I keep it tentative and leave room to correct me?
- Did I name one value, not a stack, and avoid a personality label?
- Did I follow their wording once they confirmed it?
- Did I back out cleanly the moment it missed?
- Did the move make the conversation clearer, or heavier?